in Kolkata with the legend: "New Trinamool in six months, like people want." That was seven months ago. Now, with panchayat polls due soon and the 2024 general election a year down the road, Abhishek is imparting some fresh impetus to his drive. And, faced with a worsening public perception, fanned by central agencies making newer arrests in the jobs scam, including that of TMC MLAs, the party is forced to accept the need for a course correction.

With this objective in mind, Abhishek has embarked on a two-month-long 'Jan Sanjog Yatra' across the state, from Cooch Behar in the north to Kakdwip in the south. Travelling in a motorcade, Abhishek has been stopping by gram panchayat offices and visiting ordinary villagers, lending an ear to their grievances, be it about health, roads or the non-receipt of government benefits. This, ordinarily, would be enough to shore up the party's image. However, Abhishek's goal goes beyond this. The party is in the process of selecting over 73,000 candidates for the three-tier (gram panchayat, panchayat samiti and zilla parishad) local body polls. One of the yatra's main aims, therefore, is to ensure the selection of deserving candidates through secret ballots. This is being done to usher in intra-party democracy and allay mounting anger over allegedly heavy-handed and corrupt TMC panchayat leaders and their lavish lifestyles.

ABHISHEK'S YATRA ENCOURAGES THE DEMOCRATIC SELECTION OF PANCHAYAT POLL CANDIDATES

Abhishek hopes that the democratic exercise, eschewing appointment through the usual top-down approach, would enable the selection of honest people—like TMC panchayat members Abhijit Dolabera and his wife Manju, who refused to accept houses under the Pradhan Mantri Awas Yojana (PMAY), even though they live in a thatched house. That TMC has candidates who are ready to work selflessly is what Abhishek plans to project.

CPI(M) central committee member Rabin Deb has a different take on Abhishek's motives. "He is only going around to assure demoralised party members that they need not worry, the administration is with them to see them through the panchayat polls," he says. BJP national vice-president Dilip Ghosh is not impressed either. "He's on a tour to test the mood of rural Bengal vis-à-vis the political crisis the party is going through. I don't think it will have any impact on the electorate," he says.

The bigger challenges for Abhishek, though, are internal. His effort to bring about a culture of accountability is naturally encountering resistance, but he's not backing down. "If someone thinks he'll contest as an independent candidate after being denied a ticket, he can do so, but the party's doors will be shut forever to him," he said at a rally, revealing the complex nature and scope of his endeavour.

Abhishek is walking the extra mile to be seen as a leader with a grassroots connect, to counter the perception that he had power delivered to him on a platter, or that he leads a flamboyant lifestyle. That's why the yatra has the blessings of Mamata herself. The CM made an appearance at a yatra rally in Malda and said, "My next generation of leaders is ready. On the one hand, Bobby (Firhad Hakim) and others are there, on the other hand, Abhishek and his team," she said. ■



By Prashant Srivastava

A Lutyens' Delhi address, retired bureaucrats and army officers on the advisory board of his foundation, social media profiles crammed with pictures with the who's who, going right up to Prime Minister Narendra Modi. Meet Sanjay Rai 'Sherpuria', the businessman arrested in Kanpur on April 26, on charges of cheating and forgery. Those phrases, in fact, seem inadequate given the scale of his black ops. Compared to the intricate web of deceit Sherpuria wove, even the con pulled by Gujarat-based "PMO man" Kiran Patel, who took the Jammu and Kashmir administration for a ride for months posing as a senior official in the prime minister's office—before being arrested from a luxury hotel in Srinagar in March—pales in comparison.

Sherpuria's victims span the whole gradient. From industrialists, a prominent Delhi-based one among whom "donated" Rs 6 crore to his Youth Rural Entrepreneur Foundation (YREF), to at least 15,000 youngsters, who were